



The role of public relations in a counterhegemony: A case study of the 1968 poor people's campaign

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ARTICLE INFO

Keywords:

Dr. King
Gramsci
Hegemony
Activists
Poor people's campaign

ABSTRACT

This study examined the role of public relations in Antonio Gramsci's concept of cultural hegemony, specifically in a counterhegemony. Dr. Martin Luther King, Jr.'s preparation for the 1968 Poor People's Campaign serves as a test case on how public relations can help subordinate groups confront a hegemony. This paper suggests that Gramsci's philosophy provides an analytical heuristic for researching instances of contestation. Examining counterhegemonic campaigns offer public relations practitioners a means both to think about and to intervene in the world more effectively.

1. Introduction

In 1968, Dr. Martin Luther King, Jr. and other leaders of the Southern Christian Leadership Conference (SCLC) created what they termed the Poor People's Campaign (PPC) to demand the federal government redress the employment and housing problems of those living in poverty throughout the United States. King was assassinated on April 4, 1968, before he could oversee the campaign's implementation. The PPC continued after his death, culminating in a Poor People's March of thousands of demonstrators on the nation's capital where they planned to protest daily until the government acted. The administration responded not as the campaign organizers desired but by arresting the protestors and closing the temporary camp they had built (Mantler, 2010).

While some might conclude that was a case where the dominant group crushed the subaltern – communities whose voices are unheard in the mainstream platforms of civil society (Dutta-Bergman, 2018, p. 383) – solely through force, I contend that the campaign was also undone by an inability to overcome the messaging that reinforced the status quo. Through an analysis of the discourse surrounding the PPC, this paper builds on the work of scholars who have explored the relationship between public relations and hegemony (see, e.g., Dutta & Pal, 2010, 2011; Edwards, 2011, 2018; McKie & Munshi, 2007; Munshi & Kurian, 2020; Xifra & Heath, 2015). The coalition building and message development in preparation for the PPC indicated a pathway for creating counterhegemonic discourse. I found that subaltern groups might defy

hegemonic messages by 1) taking advantage of crises that challenge the status quo, 2) crafting a unified message that brings together seemingly disparate communities around a common frame that recasts hegemonic precepts, and 3) leveraging respected intellectuals to deliver that communication. The rest of the paper will unfold as follows: a review of the literature concerning the connection between public relations and hegemony (and subaltern counterhegemony), a review of the political-cultural environment in which it occurred, and an analysis of the PPC messaging.

2. Literature review

2.1. Hegemony, subalternity, and public relations

Society has been defined as a social space marked by a constant struggle for influence, in which actors battle against each other to secure resources to further their own interest (Bourdieu, 1991). Winning in that type of melee often comes down to those who can manage discourse to create or reinforce attitudes, values, and behaviors of social and cultural environments to secure symbolic power (Edwards, 2018; Heath, Waymer, & Palenchar, 2013). And the victors in such battles have repeatedly been the ruling classes (Xifra & Heath, 2015). While that has led to voices outside the power elite being ignored or erased not only in society but in the academic literature (Dutta & Pal, 2010, 2011; Munshi & Kurian, 2020; Place & Ciszek, 2021), Cunningham (1993, p. 7) called hegemony “a social construction” because it was not predetermined but

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was instead a social force rooted in people's lived reality. Based on that supposition, a hegemony could be deposed, not with violence but with a newly constructed set of meanings on how reality should be perceived.

Previous research from subaltern studies has indicated the difficulty in overcoming systematic barriers. For instance, one of the pioneers of subaltern studies – Spivak (1988) – asked *Can the subaltern speak?*, with her answer being, *Yes, but no one is listening*. Other scholars have suggested the subaltern have some agency. Green (2011, p. 400) highlighted how Spivak's characterization of the subaltern's counterhegemonic possibilities diverged from Gramsci's conceptualization, which allowed for a “revolutionary change and the empowerment of subaltern groups in overcoming their subordination.” Spivak's (2012) later work also acknowledged a more agential notion of subalternity. I posit that the strategic use of persuasive communication and its ability to have an impact on meaning making could offer subaltern communities a way to confront hegemony.

Public relations could help subaltern communities overcome institutional hurdles to either advocate for social change, build relationships with community members and allies, or both (Dutta & Pal, 2010; Edwards, 2018; Munshi & Kurian, 2020; Place & Ciszek, 2021). Munshi and Kurian (2020, p. 10) maintained that subaltern groups should use public relations to develop “alternative narratives that challenge structures of power wielded by dominant coalitions.” Because subaltern groups have often been excluded from conventional forms of knowledge production, Dutta and Pal (2010, p. 378) expanded “the traditional conceptualizations of what constitutes communication” to include “a variety of communicative acts such as testimonio, protest marches, songs, dances, and blockades where subaltern groups articulate their voices through participation in communicative platforms.” I contend that more case studies are needed to test the specifics of how subaltern activists could use public relations, including non-traditional forms of mass communication, to defy a hegemony. This paper provides one such historical case study to help develop a blueprint for future academic studies and for current subaltern communities looking to change the perceptions of societal norms.

This study began with the concept of one subaltern community – Black Americans – which has been understudied in the public relations literature (Munshi & Edwards, 2011). The exploitation of Black people in the United States has been tied to the growth of the capitalist economy (Mullings, 2015), and exploring a discursive defense of capitalism – and the continued exclusion and economic exploitation of Black Americans – facilitated an examination of the concept of hegemony and the role of public relations in support of and in resistance to an existing power structure. During the 1950 s/1960 s civil rights movement, the communications strategies and programs of the King and the SCLC helped address state-supported segregation and discrimination but failed to realize full equality for Black Americans in all facets of society (Hon, 1997; Kern-Foxworth, 1992; Murphree, 2004). Similarly, The National Association for the Advancement of Colored People used public relations to advance the cause of Black Americans, especially during the 1960 s (Straughan, 2004). Decades later, activist organizations and networks were still using public relations to fight racism in America (Hon, 2016; Mundt, Ross, & Burnett, 2018), while public relations was also used in the anti-slavery movement of the 1800 s (Page & Adams, 2014), indicating the length of time that the problem of racism has persisted in the United States. The literature on public relations and Black Americans indicated how hard it has been to overcome entrenched systemic racism.

As the study of the PPC progressed, though, it became apparent that King (1968) wanted to include other races and ethnicities in the campaign. That multifrontal approach to attacking structural inequality echoed Gramsci's conception of subalternity, which included not only race, but also class, gender, sexual orientation, and religion (Crehan, 2016). Therefore, this study expanded to include other subaltern communities. The next section reviews Gramsci's work to help identify factors that could help a multifrontal subaltern effort craft counterhegemonic messaging.

2.2. Gramsci and hegemony

Early twentieth century political theorists Antonio Gramsci (1971) and Karl Marx (Jones, 2016) both defined hegemony as the dominion of one group over another. While Karl argued that hegemonic power was maintained through physical force, Gramsci reasoned that a governing power could win the support of dependent groups by connecting the perceived interests of those groups with their own. Gramsci developed a theory of cultural hegemony to explain how all societal classes were assimilated into accepting certain values, which helped preserve the system of domination. Gramsci (1971) divided the capitalist state into two intersecting provinces: a *political society* (i.e., entities within the state's direct control such as police, courts, and elected officials) that rules through force and a *civil society* (i.e., the spiritual, ideological, and cultural spheres such as churches, schools, and the media that provided myth, morality, customs, and cultural norms) that rules through consent. He argued that political society needed help from civil society to shape how people perceived and evaluated social reality, calling the group that exercised moral and intellectual leadership the *historical bloc*. In any given historical bloc, if civil society succeeded in making the legitimacy of political society appear to be *common sense*, then the state could rule by consent instead of by force alone, and what people assumed to be common sense was created and recreated via negotiations of competing viewpoints (Gramsci, 1971, p. 333). Those seeking to maintain power by advancing or perpetuating a particular ideology would always be in a state of mediation with other groups in society. In this paper, the assumption was that if consent is negotiated, then public relations has a role in that discourse, more specifically – in the organized attempt to persuade members of a society to accept a position or an idea.

Changing common sense and thus countering an existing hegemony, Gramsci (1971) maintained, would be difficult as people would typically hesitate to reject societal values or to question their part in that society. Thus, revolution in a Western, democratic society required a transformation of mass consciousness through a protracted *war of position*, which would be characterized by long-term political battles within civil society (Gramsci, 1971, pp. 229–238). Winning a war of position would mean the creation of a shared vision for a new, transformative future (Purcell, 2009).

The best time to initiate such revolutionary discussions, Gramsci (1971, pp. 275–6) continued, was during an *organic crisis* – a time when the masses start to question the legitimacy of the ideas and beliefs that supported the state. An organic crisis (aka, a cultural breakdown) did not necessarily mean that the people no longer accepted the theoretical and moral validations of the current system but rather that they no longer believed in those who claimed to be the arbiters of such values.

During such times, revolutionaries should supply a counterhegemony to replace the reigning hegemonic structure; that is, they needed to create an alternate interpretation of civil and political society. Gaining support for that new view of reality would require *organic intellectuals* who would encourage the rise of new systems of values and beliefs to supersede the existing hegemonic structure. In their review of Gramsci's impact on public relations, Xifra & Heath (2015, p. 197–198) noted how organic intellectuals engaged in the strategic use of communication to legitimize those in power. In a counterhegemony, though, an organic intellectual could also be someone who provided an alternative view of the world. For Gramsci (1971), an intellectual was not necessarily elitist but rather was someone who could influence consent through their activities and who helped to create and perpetuate a worldview. In sum, a counterhegemony would entail fresh leaders of civil institutions with new ideas and ideologies who could the masses an adjusted view of common sense.

2.3. Race + Class as part of counterhegemony

Creating and supporting such a revised worldview would require the formation of a collective will that posited an alternative social vision.

The implementation of a new collective would require a process of *catharsis*, which included the transition from activists defining their interests narrowly to cleansing themselves of group interests to bring formerly disparate identities onto shared ground (Gramsci, 1971, p. 367). Revolutionaries should see the struggle to counteract hegemonic narratives as a multi-frontal war of position that should be waged in conjunction with other movements (cf. Carroll, 2010). One of those fronts should be based on class – as proposed by Gramsci – as well as social movements that originated in civil society (Urry, 1981). Welding disparate forces would require each counterhegemonic group to be open to assuming features of the identity and aspirations of other groups (Purcell, 2009, pp. 296–7). That is, a counterhegemony must include a fusion of multiple forces, with each entity supporting the needs and aspirations of other oppressed groups.

In the quest to use public relations to overcome the view that subaltern issues and causes are not part of mainstream society (De Moya & Bravo, 2016), scholars should explore the power of an alliance of organizations and communities. In his review of Gramsci's work on cultural hegemony, Hall (1986) agreed that no single counterhegemonic force could successfully overthrow the dominant group. Instead of the emphasis on the exploitation of labor regardless of class or the accent on the centrality of race at the expense of the class structure of society, Hall (1986, p. 24) posited that both were necessary to provide an effective counterhegemonic bloc, even if both sides might disagree on which should be most important. That is, one must review the Western hegemony with an eye on both class and race, not one over the other.

In addition, creating a counterhegemony must include a variety of strategies and approaches because the ruling state involved so many facets of society – from schools to churches to family life (Hall, 1986, pp. 19, 26). The multitude of different battlefronts in the war of position would be too difficult to overcome by simply replacing an existing ideology with another. Instead, a better approach would be to shift perceptions about morals or values already existing in a culture (Hall, 1986, p. 23). With that in mind, I suggest that a revolutionary counterhegemonic campaign should include a multifrontal attack that adjusts societal perceptions to create a new historic bloc. Analyzing the discourses in the PPC campaign offered an example of how to address this study's primary research question: How can public relations contribute to a counterhegemonic campaign?

3. Method

Fairclough (2015, 2020) considered discourse a site of struggle, which linked his approach to critical discourse analysis (CDA) with Gramsci's war of position. In that skirmish, both elite and subaltern factions have agency, but the dominant blocs have the support of socio-cultural and political forces, as well as traditional news media structures. Gramsci (1971) maintained that the dominant class used discourse through those structures to construct a collective will that supported the current situation. Fairclough (2015) contended that CDA should focus on how blocs gather and maintain social power, so I studied how select discourses helped reinforce societal perceptions of the power structure in the late 1960 s. As a counterbalance, I then examined the messages that PPC organizers used to attempt to alter *common sense* because Gramsci (1971) argued that the revolution of subalternity required the critique and alteration of a bloc's naturalization of ideologies.

To find messaging designed to preserve the hegemonic bloc's legitimacy, I used critics' responses to a government report that blamed racial unrest on systemic issues. Other scholars of the PPC have identified that document as a means to study the view of the power elite during this time (e.g., Hamilton, 2020; Mantler, 2010, 2013). I found 95 news stories on the report via the ProQuest Historical Newspapers database. Those articles and columns were examined to find quotes from its critics, and those quotes were reviewed to determine how the establishment defended the current political and economic system.

To find primary data related to the PPC campaign and its response to the hegemonic messages, I explored the materials at the Martin Luther King Jr. Center for Nonviolent Change in Atlanta, Ga. That archive included correspondence, newspaper clippings, press conference transcripts and press releases, speeches, telephone conversation transcripts, and written statements related to the PPC. I also read King's (1968) last book, *Where do we go from here: Chaos or community?*, which outlined his argument that racial justice was impossible without economic justice. From those sources, I concentrated on the data that pertained to countering the hegemonic missives that emerged when studying the news coverage of the government report.

Once I collected the data, I used Fairclough's (2015) three steps for a CDA: analysis, interpretation, and explanation. Using that process, I analyzed campaign texts based on the following questions: What discourses were propagated? and What cultural norms did those discourses attempt to maintain or adjust? (cf. Curtin, 2011; Hall, 1997). Then, I interpreted the purpose of campaign materials and explained the power relations based on those texts. In the context of Gramsci's view of cultural hegemony and power relations, the guiding question was what discourses did each side form within contexts of struggles over meaning to redefine what was considered common sense? Answering that question required a review of the socio-political context and not just campaign materials (Fairclough, 2015, 2020), the hegemonic reaction to racial and economic unrest, and the counterhegemonic response.

4. Case study analysis

4.1. Organic crisis, the kerner report, and the hegemonic response

During the mid 1950 s and the 1960 s, Dr. Martin Luther King Jr., an American pastor and president of SCLC, fought racism in the United States with well-publicized non-violent protests that led to the passage of the Civil Rights Act of 1964 (which prohibited discrimination based on race, color, religion, sex, or national origin) and the Voting Rights Act of 1965 (which outlawed racial discrimination in voting). Unfortunately, neither piece of legislation ended racism. During the 1960 s, King realized that there could be no social justice for Black people without economic justice (Hamilton, 2020). With that in mind, King and other PPC organizers wanted to pressure the federal government to do more to fight poverty in America.

It seemed that the federal government was ready to help the 20% of the U.S. population living below the poverty line when U.S. President Lyndon B. Johnson (LBJ) announced a War on Poverty in 1964 (Nadasen, 2012, p. 22). LBJ wanted to address conditions such as inadequate housing and education, and show the world that capitalism was better than communism.

Despite LBJ's initiative, more than half of Black people were still below the poverty line in the mid-1960 s (Patterson, 1997, p. 534). Not long after the Voting Rights Act was signed in August 1965, disturbances broke out in the mostly Black community in Watts, near Los Angeles. Two years later, the United States experienced 159 race-related protests in 1967, with NBC alleging that the nation was "in the worst crisis we have known since the Civil War" (Freed, 1967). King noted that Black Americans remained frustrated with their place in American society because they had no "assurance of the right to adequate housing, or the right to an adequate income" (Washington, 1986, p. 58).

LBJ responded by forming the National Advisory Commission on Civil Disorders, nicknamed the Kerner Commission after its chairman – Illinois Governor Otto Kerner. The Kerner Commission, after seven months of investigation, blamed the inner-city violence on poverty and institutional racism, noting that "What white Americans have never fully understood – but what the Negro can never forget – is that white society is deeply implicated in the ghetto. White institutions created it, white institutions maintain it, and white society condones it" (Kerner Commission, 1968, p. 2). The nation, the commission warned, was on the verge of splitting into two radically unequal societies – one Black,

one white.

The response to the Kerner Report unveiled several connected hegemonic themes, specifically:

1. Be patient,
2. Self help,
3. Law and order, and
4. Discussing race divides us.

One of the main spokespersons (aka, organic intellectual) for the historical bloc during this time was Republican presidential candidate Richard Nixon. In contrast to the Kerner Commission's interpretation of the current system, Nixon maintained that achievement in inner cities needed to "rest not on the expectation of being given something, but on the chance to do something" (Furgurson, 1968). Nixon argued that because most European immigrants had gradually moved up America's social ladder that Black Americans could do so as well if they worked hard (i.e., *self help*) (Artz & Murphy, 2000, pp. 87–88).

LBJ could have been the counterbalance politically to Nixon, but the president, one journalist reported, was "disappointed because the [Kerner] report did not point out progress that [he] feels has been made for poor Americans under his" War on Poverty ("*Negroes and rights*," 1968, p. E2). To explain the inadequacy of his own efforts against poverty, LBJ reminded Black Americans: "You cannot correct the errors of centuries in four years or forty years" (Frankel, 1968). In other words, the president argued that Black Americans should *be patient* and change will eventually come, a message they had been told for years (see, e.g., King, 1963).

While Black Americans were told to work harder and be patient, critics of the Kerner report told whites that they needed to be protected from Black militants. Mississippi Senator James Eastland called for a return to *law and order* and said that with the Kerner report, America saw "the results of stripping our police of effective power and of coddling those who infringe on the rights of others in the name of some cause" ("*Report on Riots...*," 1968). Eastland's message resonated with many Americans as a poll of whites found that 45% (the highest response) blamed outside agitators for the "riots" (Patterson, 1997, p. 667). Critics of the Kerner report argued that downplaying the behavior of those they called *rioters* would encourage others to repeat such behavior because they knew there would be no consequences.

Nixon argued that the commission had missed the mark on what plagued inner cities by laying the blame on "everyone except the perpetrators of the riots" (Semple, 1968, p. 1). Nixon acknowledged that prejudice existed but reasoned that *talking about race "tends to divide people, to build a wall in between people"* (Semple, 1968, p. 1, italics mine). Indeed, 90% of Americans surveyed at that time were against further civil rights legislation (Dallek, 2005, p. 239). Traditionally, subaltern populations have not been included in public discourse surrounding power and societal structure (Dutta-Bergman, 2005), but this study will listen to subaltern voices and explore how one campaign attempted to respond to hegemonic messages.

4.2. Poor people's campaign

King's campaign planning took place amidst a backlash against urban unrest, Black militancy, and a federal government that had its own agenda to fight poverty (Hamilton, 2020, p. 67). In addition, 1968 was a presidential election year in which race became a leading issue (Mayer, 2002). Despite those obstacles, King and the other SCLC leaders decided in November 1967 to highlight the problems facing all of America's lower-income groups. King argued, "Poor black and white are still perishing on a lonely island of poverty in the midst of a vast ocean of material prosperity" (The Martin Luther King, Jr. Center, 2015). The proposed Poor People's Campaign would include a march on Washington, D.C. with protestors consisting of lower-income people from a variety of ethnicities such as Black Americans, Hispanic Americans, Native

Americans, and whites. King wanted the U.S. government to guarantee employment to those able to work, income to those unable to work, and an end to housing discrimination (Hamilton, 2020, p. 4).

King (1968) outlined the Black American struggle as not just for civil rights but also for changes to the existing and enduring economic consequences of racial oppression. But King also went beyond the struggles of Black Americans to include other groups hindered by the economic system. King (1968, p. 233) envisioned a new coalition: "The future of the deep structural changes we seek will not be found in the decaying political machines. It lies in new alliances of Negroes, Puerto Ricans, Labor, liberals, certain church and middle-class elements."

Yet each group had their own agendas. One Puerto Rican activist noted: "We are at each other's throats fighting for the crumbs of anti-poverty funds" (Hofmann, 1968, p. 49). Native American groups fought for sovereignty, protection of land, fishing rights, and indigenous ways of life. Appalachian whites wanted black lung treatment and to prevent surface mining. Chicano leaders focused on issues of police brutality, educational inequality, and language barriers to services. Other issues included independence for the Puerto Rican semi-colony, immediate withdrawal from Vietnam, and greater political participation for minority groups in general. King and SCLC officials hosted the Minority Group Conference in Atlanta on March 14, 1968, to explain the PPC and to listen to the aspirations of groups representing other ethnicities (SCLC, 1968e). King persuaded many of them to join the PPC, and he told the news media, "This is a march of poor people on Washington. ... Naturally, it will be predominately Negro ...because the Negro is the poorest of the poor in proportion to his size in the population. But... it will not be an all black march" (SCLC, 1968c).

King followed Gramsci's (1971) requirements for an effective war of position, as highlighted by the construction of solidaristic bonds with other marginalized groups on an equitable basis. King tried a unity-in-diversity approach that respected difference to build support for a radical alternative to America's capitalist hierarchy. Not to delve too far into the post-King PPC, but many ethnic group leaders articulated that the SCLC under new leadership did not listen to their needs as King had (Mantler, 2010). Being sensitive to the desires of other groups enabled King to craft a bloc of core activists, aka *organic intellectuals*, who could help organize and propagate campaign messages.

King also seemed to comprehend how dialogical efforts would need to navigate various identities, communities, and environments by creating a joint frame that encapsulated the needs of multiple movements. King tried to build a new historic bloc by negotiating with other subaltern groups on a communal comprehension of the causes of injustice. With the PPC, activists from different movements could communicate and find mutual ground around the frame of poverty, which provided the opportunity to coalesce each group's agenda into a broader denunciation of hegemonic structures. Such collective understandings could allow a unified movement to amalgamate single-issue protests from diverse groups into one central frame that would offer a moral-intellectual foundation.

While preparing for the campaign launch, King went to Memphis to support striking sanitation workers in their fight for union recognition and was assassinated. Former SCLC vice president Ralph Abernathy took over for King as head of the organization, and the PPC continued. The campaign included innovative activities, such as a series of *lobby-ins*, in which a Committee of 100 who represented poor people from various ethnicities pleaded their case to federal government agencies; mass demonstrations; and eight publicity-seeking caravans, including one that featured a mule-drawn wagon that traveled from Mississippi to Washington, D.C. to demonstrate how little economic progress had been made in rural areas. The caravans converged on Washington, D.C. at a temporary camp called Resurrection City that activists raised near the Lincoln Monument (SCLC, 1968b). The PPC leaders also organized The Poor People's Solidarity Day March on June 19, 1968, which included an estimated 50,000 demonstrators. Unimpressed, U.S. government officials closed Resurrection City five days after the march.

Scholars have dismissed the campaign as an unfortunate mistake, calling it a “Little Big Horn,” a “Waterloo,” an utter “debacle” (Laurent, 2018, p. 9). Also, despite the organizers’ protests to the contrary, the national news media and the Black press both limited the effectiveness of the campaign by framing it as being focused on race alone and not race plus class (Mantler, 2010). Hon (1997, p. 187) argued that the assassination of King adversely affected the campaign’s effectiveness. Still, the PPC married class struggle together with the fight for interracial equality in a manner that neither diminished nor restricted either aim (cf. Laurent, 2018). That means the PPC offered insights into the dissemination and negotiation of multifrontal counterhegemonic messages.

4.3. Counterhegemonic discourse

To avoid the distraction of how the SCLC tried to handle the campaign without King and realizing, as Fairclough (2020, p. 115) noted, the central concern of a CDA was the critique of ideology and not just the material, this paper focused on the precepts and messages that King established for the campaign. Each subsection will entail a review of how the PPC organizers responded to hegemonic messages, starting with the *be patient* theme.

4.3.1. The argument against *be patient*

Throughout his public career, King (1968, p. 96) argued against the *be patient* message, noting that the Black person could not achieve emancipation “by passively waiting for the white race voluntarily to grant it to him.” King (1968, p. 93) maintained, “The virtue of patience will become a vice if it accepts so leisurely an approach to social change.”

King’s counterhegemonic response during the PPC can be found in a letter sent to the U.S. president, Congress, and Supreme Court. In that letter, King reminded government officials that Black people had already experienced “nearly two centuries of oppression and terror and a civil war” (SCLC, 1968d, p. 1). King added: “Two hundred years after the Declaration of Independence will the right to the pursuit of happiness mock the majority of Negroes locked up in an economic underworld of poverty, joblessness and unemployment?” (SCLC, 1968d, p. 1).

In the letter, and in other PPC materials and speeches, King proposed an active revolution in values. Recalling a document that introduced the principles of life, liberty, and the pursuit of happiness to the nation, King attached the PPC to key American ideals. By using the Declaration of Independence, King highlighted a paradox: the mythologizing of the document as the basis of a nation founded on liberty and equality contrasted with the stain of slavery and opposition to not just civil but also economic rights for all Americans. The authors of the Declaration of Independence had constructed a narrative that justified political revolution and arranged explanatory groundwork for a future political state. King attempted to remind Americans of those principles to illustrate the possibility of living up to its standards by addressing economic inequality. Using an iconic American document was an attempt to associate the plight of those suffering from poverty with the nation’s founding fathers who were also trying to address an unjust economic system. King also reiterated how long (*two hundred years and two centuries*) that Black Americans had suffered inequality. He pointed out that Black Americans had been deprived of life, denied liberty, and prevented from pursuing happiness for centuries, so action was needed, not more patience. With the unrest of 1967 fresh on American minds, the PPC tried to use repurpose American ideals into counterhegemonic messaging and redefine what was considered *common sense*. King called for a transformation of the capitalist system and its value structure, which he maintained ran counter to the aspiration of the nation’s founding document.

4.3.2. The argument against *self help*

The PPC campaign failed to overcome the *be patient* message, in part,

because that hegemonic concept was conflated with the *America as the land of opportunity* mythos. The historic bloc connected the two notions with a self-help discourse, which suggested that anyone could succeed in America with enough effort, so those who failed must not be trying hard enough. If any person (or group) could not succeed in America, the hegemonic argument went, then it spoke to something about those individuals instead of a systemic issue. Also, the argument continued, some Blacks had worked hard to achieve the American dream, so it was possible (Artz & Murphy, 2000, pp. 87–88). An August 9, 1967, Harris poll showed how entrenched that discourse was in the American mindset when it found that 70% of those surveyed agreed with the statement: “Negroes have less ambition than white people” (Erskine, 1967–1968, p. 667).

This section and the next two sections will focus on the responses that King (1968) made to hegemonic messages in his last book, with support from other PPC materials. King (1968, pp. xiii–xiv) insisted that “the larger economic problems confronting the Negro community will only be solved by federal programs involving billions of dollars.” To accomplish that goal, he needed to correct the blame-the-victim narrative by highlighting how the system, not poor people, was at fault for economic inequality. As part of that argument, he maintained that those living in poverty already worked hard. In a campaign brochure, SCLC officials (1968a, italics mine) argued, “Most poor American adults *work hard every day* but are not paid enough for a decent life for their families.” Another facet of the PPC argument was that color more than laziness had affected the ability of Black people to succeed in America. King (1968, p. 110) quoted “unfeeling and insensitive whites” who said: “Other immigrant groups such as the Irish, the Jews and the Italians started out with similar handicaps, and yet they made it. Why haven’t the Negroes done the same?” He answered it was because: “Negroes were brought [to America] in chains.” King challenged the imbalance of power by not only illuminating the material needs of the most vulnerable groups in America but also by explaining the systemic reasons for their situation. King (1968, p. 147) concluded: “The economic highway to power has few entry lanes for Negroes.”

King challenged the power relations at the societal, institutional, and situational levels. King highlighted the power imbalance the subaltern encountered in a nation with pre-determined characteristics for them. King’s metaphoric expressions such as *economic highway* and the lack of *entry* onto said highway – as well as the reminder through visual imagery of how Black Americans were forced to come to America in *chains* – connoted the limitations that society had placed on the subaltern. King tried to reconfigure harmful discursive associations of those in poverty (especially Black Americans) with perceived sloth (indeed they *work hard every day*) to denaturalize the ideological basis of racism. King wanted to shift blame for poverty from the subaltern to the capitalist system.

However, while King and the SCLC could encode a representation with specific meanings, audiences used their own frames of understanding to decode it as a meaningful discourse (Hall, 1986). That is, the *anyone could succeed with more effort* rhetoric was so embedded in American culture that one single campaign failed to revise that mindset. Gramsci (1971, p. 340) encouraged counterhegemonic activists to never “tire of repeating its own arguments” because “new conceptions have an extremely unstable position among the popular masses,” especially when they were “in contrast with orthodox convictions.”

4.3.3. The argument against *law and order*

Another reality that the PPC organizers had to overcome was that in times of crisis the historic bloc might mitigate counterhegemonic messaging with the construction of social panic and with the identification of select groups of people as the source of the crisis (Carroll, 2010). In this case, the bloc branded those protesting racial and economic inequities as *rioters* (as opposed to *protestors*), which necessitated the need for more law-and-order instead of addressing systemic issues.

King attempted to counter that message with a *moral governance*

discourse, which placed an onus on a set of former civil rights supporters. King (1968, p. 93) argued: “Over the last few years many Negroes have felt that their most troublesome adversary was not the obvious bigot of the Ku Klux Klan ..., but the white liberal who is more devoted to ‘order’ than to justice, who prefers tranquility to equality.” For King, economic justice was not only more important than peace, but it could not be achieved unless unearned *tranquility* was disturbed. That is, the current economic system had to change, and for it to change people had to act. King wanted to inspire those outside the subaltern to join the PPC in fighting against the political and social power relations that he considered the main cause for the subordination of the poor. King (1968, p. 51) concluded: “What is most needed is a coalition of Negroes and liberal whites that will work to make both parties truly responsive to the needs of the poor.”

After establishing common ground with his audience by explaining how a *coalition* of concerned citizens could result in a better society, King guided them on how to defeat economic, social, and political oppression. King (1968, p. 142) wanted “creative dissenters who will call our beloved nation to a higher destiny, to a new plateau of compassion, to a more noble expression of humaneness.” King wanted to persuade his version of the in-group (i.e., those in *our beloved nation* who were *creative, compassionate, noble, and humane*) to confront economic inequality and remove the underlying reason for protests as part of a *higher destiny*. King maintained that if the nation wanted peace, then there needed to be a focus on correcting the system that planted and nurtured the seeds of discontent. King (1968, p. 22) reasoned: “Social justice and progress are the absolute guarantors of riot prevention. ... Negroes hold only one key to the double lock of peaceful change. The other is in the hands of the white community.”

Unfortunately for PPC organizers, the *law-and-order* frame in response to the violence in Black communities in 1967 was entrenched, displacing King’s moral claim to civil and economic justice. The fear-based rhetoric was so effective in shaping public opinion that liberal politicians joined the conservative call for tougher laws, longer sentences, and more prisons (Bedingfield, 2019). As a result, the historic bloc gained popular consent, echoing Gramsci’s (1971) contention that established *common sense* was hard to overcome. As King discovered, alternate discourses that attempted to contradict the hegemonic context were often dismissed as radical, illogical, or disorderly (Hall, Jefferson, Clarke & Roberts, 1978).

4.3.4. The argument against not discussing race / the multifrontal approach

The historical bloc contended that it would be better not to mention anything that contradicted the *common sense* that reinforced the current structure. In this case, that meant that it was better not to discuss race or economic disparities at all, as that might lead to uneasiness for those who benefitted from the current situation. That illustrated how dialogue can often be muted by the power elite.

King and the other counterhegemonic leaders argued that silence on uncomfortable issues lead to division among the subaltern, which reinforced the status quo. King (1968, p. 132) noted: “The Pharaohs had a favorite and effective strategy to keep their slaves in bondage: keep them fighting among themselves. The divide-and-conquer technique has been a potent weapon in the arsenal of oppression.” As a counter to not speaking about race, the PPC organizers attempted to build a multiracial partnership focused on poverty that discussed both race and economic class. When the title of King’s final book asked, *Where do we go from here: Chaos or community?*, King answered *community*. One of the prevailing discourses in King’s (1968, p. 52) book was: “In a multiracial society no group can make it alone.” King frequently touted the participation of groups outside Black Americans who had joined the PPC (See, e.g., SCLC, 1968b; SCLC, 1968c). King was determined to unite the groups in the shared purpose of economic justice, but he knew they needed to overcome hegemonic narratives.

To do so, King argued that both race and class needed to be discussed because they were part of the current reality, and that the poor were

detached from an America grounded in capitalism. King (1968, p. 141) asked, “Why are there forty million poor people in a nation overflowing with such unbelievable affluence?” King asserted that the imbalanced access to opportunity and wealth, rather than the act of discussing social and economic injustice, tainted the fabric of American society.

King’s argument failed to adjust the perception of *common sense* enough to achieve PPC goals. After his death, the other PPC organizers did make limited gains. Campaign leaders persuaded the government to fund a \$100 million program for free and reduced-price lunches for poor children, the release of surplus commodities to the nation’s 1000 poorest counties, \$25 million for Office of Economic Opportunity (OEO) and Head Start programs, the hiring of more than 1000 poor people by OEO agencies, and a reduction in the cost of the food stamp program to recipients (Mantler, 2013). Yet the PPC failed to persuade the government to make any substantial structural changes to its economic system. The poverty rate has remained relatively stable from 1968 to 2020, with 12.8% of Americans living in poverty in 1968 (U.S. Census Bureau, 1970) and 11.4% in 2020 (U.S. Census, 2022).

5. Discussion

The purpose of this study was to examine a specific campaign to determine ways in which public relations could support counterhegemonic efforts. In part because the subaltern start at a distinct disadvantage in fighting the dominant group and perhaps also due to King’s death, the 1968 Poor People’s Campaign failed to alter conventional wisdom regarding class and race in America. Although subaltern communities received some support for their plight from the Kerner Commission, the PPC organizers lost the war of position to the existing power structure. Nevertheless, I argue that the case offers some insights into how public relations might be used as one component in confronting a hegemonic bloc.

As Gramsci (1971) and Hall (1986) maintained, a hegemony cannot be overthrown with a single blow. They both noted, though, that a hegemony could be overcome because such a system was in a constant state of flux with a variety of social contestations. In that ongoing negotiation of meaning making, subaltern communities could use public relations to help them shift power by producing discourses that continually contest the status quo, which could help facilitate the subaltern’s escape from forms of thinking tied to capitalist fixities.

Specifically, during an organic crisis, public relations could be used to develop counterhegemonic framing that both builds consensus among subaltern groups and attempts to adjust societal perceptions, while employing organic intellectuals to deliver that messaging. Those organic intellectuals would have a symbiotic relationship with their subaltern community but also would be dedicated to the revolutionary aspirations and empowerment of a collective. In the struggle over ideas, those leaders would not only articulate issues and ideas relevant to their community but would also choreograph a monolithic sensibility and consciousness to challenge and deconstruct the domineering mainstream. When an opportunity to contest the status quo seemed to appear in the late 1960s, King understood that large scale resistance necessitated the existence of a shared unifying narrative that transcended the differences between counterhegemonic groups. King succeeded in selling that vision to groups representing other races and ethnicities whose interests aligned with the vision propagated in the PPC. Based on that example, subaltern groups should go beyond their own proximate interests to construct a holistic, encompassing conception of the interest of like-minded communities. For instance, to defeat the grow-or-die logic of capitalism, organizers of dissent need not exemplify a class or a racial or ethnic community but rather could identify a joint issue broad enough to amalgamate oppositional groups around a substitute for the hegemony.

That framing could lead seemingly disparate communities to recognize the threads that affect each group and could lead to broader involvement in counterhegemonic efforts. Public relations practitioners

could help craft, disseminate, and negotiate a unified discourse that could survive the fluid coalitions and sporadic responses that might derail the war of position needed to create social change. Promulgating a steady drumbeat of agreed-upon communal messages could not only reinterpret and adjust norms and values, but also insert and maintain a belief in the possibility of a radically transformed future. Then, perhaps public relations could help an oppositional culture endure against the marginalizing discourse of the existing power elite.

It is important to note, though, that this study was based on a single case. Even then, it was only one facet of the Poor People's Campaign, and I singled out texts that fit into the prevailing themes of either the hegemonic or counterhegemonic forces. It would be interesting to examine the SCLC public relations efforts after Abernathy took over leadership of the organization and the campaign. It might also be enlightening to study the campaign from the perspective of other groups besides SCLC such as other race- and class-based groups or the National Welfare Organization. Also, the Poor People's Campaign exists as an independent organization today; a future study could compare the actions, goals, and messaging of the current group with King's initial campaign. While this historical case study concentrated on the 1968 PPC, more studies are required to gain additional insight into how various subaltern groups in different cultures used public relations – to investigate, for instance, whether crisis, intellectuals, and collective frames were associated with achieving group goals. Even in this selective review of the original PPC, though, the study provided a guide for how to examine public relations campaigns that challenge adherence to the status quo.

More studies that work with and originate from subaltern communities are needed. Future studies could highlight, evaluate, and critique power systems that preserve traditional systems of knowledge production and meaning making that silence subaltern communities. In addition to the Gramscian view of the subaltern and counterhegemony, scholars could also explore other theoretical and methodological approaches to deepen understanding of how subaltern communities speak despite structural impediments. Even more beneficial, perhaps, will be further research on how to use public relations principles and strategies to approach addressing systemic inequities.

6. Conclusion

In this paper, I posit that to progress toward a standard for the use of public relations in a counterhegemony, scholars and practitioners need to examine movements and campaigns that have confronted the status quo to think about how to intervene in the world more effectively. Reviewing one discourse of dissent and resistance helped provide possible specifics into how subaltern groups could use public relations.

I also suggest that concepts from Gramsci's political philosophy provide an analytical heuristic for researching other instances of contestation. Organizing historical cases studies in the fashion suggested in this paper – reviewing organic crises to offer context for the case, analyzing organic intellectuals who served as spokespersons for the subaltern, and considering if the frames used were focused on singular topics or were designed to combine the needs of multiple communities – provides public relations historians a structure by which to analyze subaltern communication efforts.

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I have no conflicts of interests to disclose.

Declaration of Competing Interest

none.

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